

As healers they were greatly valued, especially in remote areas with no access to other medical care. In their common role of midwives, cunning folk blended mystical spells, herbal remedies, and practical help. In fact, the more that cunning folk aroused official disapproval, particularly from the church, and the more they were prosecuted, the greater their fame. A handful had national reputations, and it even became the fashion in society circles to consult cunning folk.

Acceptance and celebration

Much of the cunning folks' ancient knowledge, particularly in Scandinavia, was held in "black books" and collections of magic spells, later called grimoires. Some spell books contained no more than simple remedies for various ailments, from toothache to back pains, while others promised dizzying powers. *La Poule Noire* ("The Black Pullet"),



◀ *Poule Noire* talisman

The spell book *La Poule Noire* describes 22 silk talismans and bronze rings. A Turkish sage was said to have revealed their secrets to a Napoleonic soldier. This one, Number 10, "will make you invisible to all eyes."

for example, was a guide to the construction of magical talismanic rings. These rings promised great powers, the most extraordinary of which was the ability to create the Black Pullet—a hen that laid golden eggs. Any individual achieving this power was said to have access to unlimited wealth.

Spell books such as *La Poule Noire* exerted a growing influence well into the 19th century, particularly in France, sparked in part by the growing scholarly interest in folklore and legend. Indeed, gaining possession of a lucrative power is a theme in many fairy tales and magical stories that have remained popular into the 20th and 21st centuries.

"Each community had its specialists ... and people had great faith in them."

ANNE MARIE DJUPDALEN ON 19TH-CENTURY NORWEGIAN FOLK HEALERS



▲ Herbal remedy

Valeriana officinalis, a relaxant and cure for insomnia, was among the cunning folks' most favored herbal remedies. Valerian was also frequently hung in barns, as people believed that its pungency guarded animals from malign spirits.

MOR SAETHER (1793–1851)

Miracle woman

Of all the cunning folk, none was more celebrated, almost venerated, than the Norwegian "miracle woman" Mor (Mother) Saether. Her desire to heal amounted to a kind of vocation, one augmented by an instinctive and wide-ranging understanding of herbal medicines. She was imprisoned for quackery three times—in 1836, 1841, and 1844. In the end, the public outcry against her incarceration was such that the Norwegian Supreme Court freed her. Among her most famous patients was the patriot and poet Henrik Wergeland. Her rheumatic salve was still being sold into the 1980s.

